



A climber for two where players bid contracts and 10s shovel sets

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Concept

Dopplin is a two-player climbing and shedding game played with a shortened double deck.

Players lead and beat singles, pairs, sets, runs, and connected sets. There are no bombs. Instead, 10s can shovel an opponent’s set into your hand, leaving the 10s behind as the new active play.

Before play begins, players bid for contracts that raise the stakes and set the terms of the hand: who leads, how set-aside cards enter play, and what the declarer must achieve. Victory comes from reading your hand, choosing the right contract, and knowing when to shed quickly, hold back, or shovel at the right moment.

Setup

Players: 2.

Cards: Use 2 standard 54-card decks and keep only 5s, 10s, J, Q, K, A, 2s, and Jokers, excluding all Diamonds.

This gives exactly **46 cards**: 6 cards each of 10, J, Q, K, A, and 2; 4 ordinary 5s; 2 Heart 5s; 2 Small Jokers and 2 Big Jokers.

Deal: Deal **18 cards** to each player. Set the remaining **10 cards** aside face down, unused except as noted by certain contracts.

First bidder: Randomly choose the first bidder for the first hand. In later hands, the player with fewer points bids first. If scores are tied, the player who did not win the previous hand bids first.

Card Rank

Highest to lowest: Heart 5 > Big Joker > Small Joker > other 5s > 2 > A > K > Q > J > 10.

The **Heart 5** is separate from the other 5s. It cannot combine with other-suit 5s in pairs and sets. The two Heart 5s may still pair with each other.

Jokers may be played as singles or as same-kind pairs. They are not used in runs or connected sets.

Contracts

Before play, starting with the first bidder, players alternate chances to declare. A player may **pass** or declare a contract. Passing before any contract is declared does not end the auction. Once a contract has been declared, the other player may declare a stronger contract or pass. A pass after a contract has been declared ends the auction. A **Heavenly** declaration ends the auction immediately.

If both players pass, play **Quiet**; the first bidder leads first. If a contract is declared, the player who declared the final contract is the **declarer**. Unless a contract says otherwise, the declarer leads first.

Contract order: Quiet < Buried Treasure < Breakaway < Forced Shovel < Red Finish < The Chase < Blackout < Shutout < Heavenly.

Contract	Requirement
Quiet	First bidder leads first. First player to shed out wins.
Buried Treasure	Before play, reveal the top 3 set-aside cards. The declarer chooses 1 revealed card and adds it to their hand. Then the non-declarer may choose 1 of the remaining revealed cards and add it to their hand, or decline. Any other revealed cards remain unused. Declarer wins by shedding out first. If the non-declarer sheds out first, declarer fails.
Breakaway	Declarer wins by shedding out first. If the non-declarer sheds out first, declarer fails.
Forced Shovel	Declarer may only declare this contract if they hold at least one 10. Declarer wins by shedding out first after either using shovel or including one or more 10s in their final play. Until then, declarer may not play 10s except as a shovel. If declarer declines a legal shovel opportunity, or if the non-declarer sheds out first, declarer fails.
Red Finish	The non-declarer leads first. Declarer wins by shedding out first, and declarer’s final legal play must contain the Heart 5. If the non-declarer sheds out first, declarer fails.
The Chase	Before play, the declarer takes the top 3 of the set-aside cards into their hand. The non-declarer leads first. Declarer must shed out before the non-declarer escapes. The non-declarer escapes immediately if, after playing cards on their own turn, they have 3 or fewer cards in hand. Shoveling cannot trigger escape.
Blackout	The non-declarer leads first. Declarer wins by shedding out first without leading a single to an empty pile. If declarer leads a single to an empty pile or the non-declarer sheds out first, declarer fails.
Shutout	Declarer must shed out before the non-declarer plays any card. Passing does not count as playing a card. If the non-declarer plays any card before declarer goes out, declarer fails immediately.
Heavenly	Declarer must complete a Shutout. In addition, after declarer’s final play, the non-declarer gets one last chance to beat that final play with a legal higher matching play. If they can, declarer fails immediately. If they cannot, declarer succeeds.

Turn Flow

A lead may be any legal play. On your turn, either **pass** or play a legal combination that **beats the current play**. If the opponent passes, the last player who played clears the pile and leads again.

The hand ends when one player has no cards left, or earlier through contract failure or non-declarer escape.

Legal Plays

Play	Requirement
Single	1 card.
Pair	2 equal-rank cards. The two Heart 5s may pair. Same-kind Jokers may pair.
Set	3 to 6 equal-rank cards, where available: triple, quad, 5-, or 6-of-a-kind.
Single run	Exactly 4 or 5 consecutive singles, using only 10, J, Q, K, A.
Connected sets	3+ consecutive equal-size groups: connected pairs, triples, quads, 5-, or 6-of-a-kind groups. Only 10, J, Q, K, A may be used.

Comparison: A play only beats the **same type** with matching size, length, and structure. Connected sets must match both group size and number of groups. Sets compare by rank. Runs and connected sets compare by their highest card or highest group.

No bombs: There are no bombs and no cross-type beating.

Shovel

10s have a special **shovel** power. On your turn, you may play 10s to capture the opponent's current rank set if your 10-play has exactly one fewer card than the target set.

Shovel play	Captures
10	A pair.
10-10	A triple.
10-10-10	A 4-of-a-kind.
10-10-10-10	A 5-of-a-kind.
10-10-10-10-10	A 6-of-a-kind.

The captured set is added to the shoveling player's hand. The played 10s stay on the pile as the current active play.

The opponent must now beat the 10s or pass.

Example: Opponent plays Q-Q-Q. You play 10-10. You take Q-Q-Q into your hand. The active play is now 10-10.

A shovel may only capture the opponent's current play. You cannot shovel your own earlier play.

Limits: Shovel may capture only ordinary same-rank sets: 10s, Js, Qs, Ks, As, 2s, and ordinary 5s. It cannot capture Heart 5s or Jokers.

Scoring

Scoring format: Success / Failure. If the declarer succeeds, they score the first value; if they fail, the opponent scores the second value.

Contract	Score
Quiet	5
Buried Treasure	10 / 5
Breakaway	15 / 10
Forced Shovel	20 / 15
Red Finish	25 / 20
The Chase	30 / 20
Blackout	35 / 25
Shutout	40 / 30
Heavenly	45 / 35

In **Quiet**, there is no declarer: the first player to shed out scores 5 points.

Match: Play to **100 points** for a short match, or **150 points** for a longer match, or to any previously agreed number of hands or points. If playing to points, the match ends after a hand in which at least one player reaches the target.

Design Notes and Credits

Dopplin is mainly inspired by Dalian Red 5, with additional inspiration from Big A and Dou Dizhu.

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